BOSTON · 311 OPEN DATA · 2025

STREET SIGNAL

Every resident who reports a problem is left guessing whether they were ignored or whether they were being unreasonable. We answer that question with the city's own records — in one sentence, with receipts.

"Is it just me, or is my street being ignored?"

— the question nobody can answer today

You report the rats. Weeks later an email says **Closed.** Nothing on your street has changed.

Two doubts follow, and both land as self-blame: **is this normal for a city?** and **did anything actually happen?**

The city knows both answers. It knows your case number, its deadline, your street's whole history, and what "closed" really meant. **You are the only party in the transaction operating blind — and you're the one it's happening to.**

THE DOUBT IS WELL FOUNDED

58,005

CASES BOSTON CLOSED IN 2025 AS **"NOTED ONLY"** — recorded, with no fix logged

That is the recorded moment a person was managed rather than helped. It sits in a public file, and no resident has ever been shown it.

31.8%
MISSED THE CITY'S OWN DEADLINE

40.2%
OF VOLUME IS A REPEAT — SAME PLACE, SAME PROBLEM

4.8h
MEDIAN CLOSE — THE FLATTERING NUMBER

90.8d
99TH PERCENTILE — WHERE PEOPLE ACTUALLY LIVE

WHY NOBODY HAS BUILT THIS

THE DATA IS OPEN, AND ALMOST UNUSABLE.

There is no prose in it.

267,187 rows carry no description field — only short category codes. 2,982 distinct titles exist, but the top thirty cover **84.9%** of every row, and one of them is 60,641 identical strings.

Drop that into a vector index and you get sixty thousand copies of the same point. Retrieval becomes a coin flip.

And most of it isn't residents.

57% of the file is city staff logging their own rounds. Skip that filter and the app tells someone *"eleven neighbours reported this too"* when seven were an inspector.

> That is the difference between solidarity and a warm lie — and it's the one mistake this product cannot afford to make.

WORTH PUSHING ON

13 SOURCES

No — 9 residents reported rodent activity on 328 Dartmouth St in 2025.

The city logged 4 more itself, on top of the resident reports.

ISD is the department that handles these.

12 of the cases there closed as "noted only" — recorded, with no fix logged.

288 properties on this street · typical one built 1890 · 31% owner-occupied · 311 Service Requests + Property Assessment · through 31 Dec 2025

LEGITIMACY FIRST. LOGISTICS SECOND.

The opening sentence is the one that dissolves the shame. The department name, the timeline, the parcel history — all of it comes after.

> Every figure traces to a real case ID that opens the city's own record. Citations are bound from retrieved rows, so the model cannot invent one.

HOW IT WORKS

① **Classify intent** — out of scope or personal? refuse, never search

⟶ Hard filters — street · category · residents only, from **this turn only**

⟶ Stage 1 — citywide category card

⟶ Stage 2 — street-level card inside that category

② **Sensitivity gate** — address detail withheld unless asked for

⟶ Score floor — no match → "I don't have a source I trust"

③ **Output** — every claim bound to a field, or it isn't written

THREE GUARDRAILS, VISIBLE ON SCREEN

You can watch which one fired. Ask for a landlord's phone number and the input guard blocks it **before any search runs**.

① INPUT	② RETRIEVAL	③ OUTPUT
blocked	never ran	refused

> Being told nothing is honest beats being told something plausible.

BOSTON'S QUEUE HAS NO SEVERITY FIELD. WE ADDED ONE.

A rat infestation and a misplaced trash barrel enter the same queue, with the same clock.

Our first ranking let parking enforcement — 22% of the whole file — bury everything that can actually hurt someone. So crowd size goes through a log, and tier does the work.

Top 40 is now 24 safety + 16 habitability. Zero parking.

> Backing counts start from the residents who really filed. An upvote joins a number that already existed — not invented engagement.

TIER	SHARE	NOTED ONLY	WHO HANDLES IT
P1 Safety	14.2%	19.8%	**Human, now**
P2 Home	7.0%	63.5%	**Human, scheduled**
P3 Routine	**74.6%**	30.0%	System proposes, human approves
P4 Admin	4.2%	7.8%	Fully automated

> 78.8% of the queue is routine or transactional — and it is choking the 21% that needs a person.

THE FOUR PRIORITY TIERS

THEY ANSWER ONE QUESTION: WHO SHOULD TOUCH THIS?

Not *is this real* — all 267,187 rows are real people. Nothing is discarded, only routed.

P1 · SAFETY

HUMAN, NOW

Someone can be physically hurt and the harm is irreversible. A broken sidewalk hurts nobody until it's a fractured hip.

83%

OVERDUE ON "MAKE SAFE" — THE WORST CATEGORY IN THE FILE, AND 71% RESIDENT-FILED

14.2% of volume · 15.0% open

P2 · HOME

HUMAN, SCHEDULED — WITH A RETURN VISIT

It makes a home unlivable, it recurs, and one visit doesn't end it. Nobody dies of rats — you just don't sleep, and don't tell the neighbours.

63.5%

CLOSED "NOTED ONLY" vs A 30% BASELINE · RODENTS ALONE: 86%

7.0% of volume · only 3.6% overdue

P3 · ROUTINE

SYSTEM PROPOSES, HUMAN APPROVES IN BATCH

Real, needs a decision — but repetitive enough that nobody should be opening tickets one at a time.

74.6%

OF THE WHOLE QUEUE · PARKING ALONE IS 60,641 CASES

32.4% open · 36.3% overdue

P4 · ADMIN

FULLY AUTOMATED, NO HUMAN

Zero judgment. There is no decision to make — you either qualify for a bin or you don't.

10.5d

MEDIAN FOR A RECYCLING BIN · 0.1% OPEN, 38.5% LATE

4.2% of volume · 99% resident-filed

1 · IF NOBODY ACTS?

Physical harm → P1. An unlivable home → P2. Deterioration → P3. Mild annoyance → P4.

2 · HOW MUCH JUDGMENT?

Discretion and site knowledge → P1/P2. Repetitive discretion → P3. None → P4.

3 · DOES ONE VISIT END IT?

No → P2. That's why "return visit" is in the definition, not an implementation note.

> These assignments are ours, not the city's — the schema carries no severity field, and that absence is the finding. The boundaries are a judgment call: **Encampments sits awkwardly in P2**, since depending on what's reported it is as much a P1 safety question.

THE MAP IS THE ARGUMENT

YOU SEE WHAT'S BEING IGNORED BEFORE YOU READ A WORD.

- **Pin height is priority.** The skyline shows you the backlog.
- **Ground ring is how many neighbours** reported the same thing.
- **Colour is what kind of problem** — six categories, not 155 city codes.
- **Click any pin** and it opens the answer for that street.

> Colours were checked with a colour-blindness validator in light and dark. Eight categories failed; six pass every test. Colour is never the only signal — everything carries its name too.

- Pests & rodents
- Trash & dumping
- Housing conditions
- Streets & sidewalks
- Lights & signals
- Vehicles & parking

> Three.js, extruded from the city's own neighbourhood GeoJSON. **No tile server, no map vendor, no network.**

WHAT IT COSTS TO RUN

ONE HTML FILE.
NOTHING ELSE.

LAYER	WHAT IT IS
Data	8,898 cards from 267,187 rows, 58 streets of parcel facts, 26 polygons — baked in
Retrieval	Plain JavaScript. Filters → two stages → gate → floor
Answer	Assembled from counted fields, never generated
Map	Three.js from city GeoJSON — no tile server
State	localStorage — votes, reports, points
LLM	Granite 3.1 8B on local Ollama, optional, keyword fallback

The build step is offline: a Python script rolls 267,000 coded rows into readable cards in about **four seconds, with zero model calls**.

> No server. No API keys. No per-query cost. On dead conference wifi, on a bus, in a basement apartment — it still answers.

SERVING COST:
A STATIC FILE.

THE HONEST LIMITS

- **Granite runs locally only.** Published, it falls back to keyword classification. The prose is assembled from fields either way — which is why citations can't drift.
- **Property Assessment covers 58 streets**, not all of Boston. Their API caps at 32,000 rows and blocks `NULLIF`.
- **Approximate street matches say so.** "Beacon St" can land on a nearby intersection; the answer flags it rather than passing off another street's numbers as yours.
- **Reports stay on the device.** It's a community signal, not a filing with the City — real reports still go to 311.

Stop shouting into a void. Start being someone *with a case*.

Street Signal · built on Analyze Boston open data